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National Flag of Canada Day

February 15 was declared National Flag of Canada Day in 1996. It marks the day in 1965 when our red and white maple leaf flag was first raised over Parliament Hill in Ottawa, and indeed, hundreds of communities across Canada. Red and white were designated as Canada's official colours in 1921 by His Majesty George V. This is a perfect opportunity to celebrate our flag and what it stands for — a Dominion that is the envy of the world.



Raising of the first maple leaf flag on Parliament Hill
Ottawa, Ontario. February 15, 1965

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February 15 — National Flag of Canada Day — is the perfect opportunity to pay homage to the flag and to share our pride in Canada and in being Canadian.

*Our Flag. Our Pride. Celebrate it!
Happy National Flag
of Canada Day!*

The material in this brochure is intended to provide readers with background on the National Flag of Canada, including its history, its symbolism and flag etiquette. Further information, including a “Teachers’ Corner” with suggested Flag Day activities, is available on the Canadian Heritage Web site at: www.canadianheritage.gc.ca/flagday.



Proclamation by Her Majesty the Queen
of the National Flag of Canada
January 28, 1965

The Birth of the National Flag of Canada

At the time of Confederation, Canada's national flag remained the Royal Union Flag or the Union Jack. However, Sir John A. Macdonald, Canada's first Prime Minister, flew the Canadian Red Ensign as a distinctive flag of Canada. Following the Second World War, in 1945, an Order in Council authorized the flying of the Canadian Red Ensign from federal government buildings, in Canada and abroad.



Prime Minister Pearson's preferred flag,
"From Sea to Sea."

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In 1964, Prime Minister Lester B. Pearson made the creation of a new Canadian flag a priority. John Matheson, Member of Parliament, was Prime Minister Pearson's key advisor and supporter in this objective. On June 15, 1964, the Prime Minister presented his proposed flag to the House of Commons, launching a divisive Canadian flag debate. After three months without resolution, the question of a national flag was referred to an all-party committee.

In October 1964, after eliminating thousands of proposals, the Special Committee on a Canadian Flag was left with three possible designs: one incorporating three red maple leaves with blue bars (nicknamed the "Pearson Pennant"), a flag with a single stylized red maple leaf on a white square with red bars, and another version that contained both the Union Jack and three fleurs-de-lis.



Final flag design selected from Group B
by the Canadian Flag Committee

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Commandant's Flag, Royal Military College
Reproduced with the permission of the Royal Military College, 2007

On October 29, 1964, the committee recommended to the House of Commons that the single leaf, red and white design be adopted. Debate in Parliament continued, however, and it was only at the early hour of 2:15 a.m. on December 15, 1964, that the motion to adopt the National Flag of Canada was carried by a vote of 163 to 78. Approval by the Senate came on December 17, 1964, and on January 28, 1965, the National Flag of Canada was proclaimed by Her Majesty Queen Elizabeth II, to take effect on February 15, 1965.

The inspiration for a red and white flag came from Dr. George Stanley, Dean of Arts at the Royal Military College in Kingston, Ontario. Impressed by the Commandant's flag at the College (a mailed fist holding three maple leaves on a red and white ground), Dr. Stanley suggested to Mr. John Matheson a similar design with a single red maple leaf at the centre. This red – white – red pattern bore a strong sense of Canadian history: the combination had been used as early as 1899 on the General Service Medal issued by Queen Victoria.

General Service
Medal, 1899



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The Maple Leaf

Well before the coming of the first European settlers, Canada's Aboriginal peoples had discovered the edible properties of maple sap, which they gathered every spring. According to many historians, the maple leaf began to serve as a Canadian symbol as early as 1700.

The following are some examples of how the maple leaf grew in public consciousness as a symbol of our country until it finally became official on February 15, 1965, as an integral component of the National Flag of Canada.

In 1834, Ludger Duvernay is reported to have proposed the maple leaf as an emblem of Canada when the *Société Saint-Jean-Baptiste* was founded on June 24 of that year.

In 1836, *Le Canadien*, a newspaper published in Lower Canada (now Quebec), referred to it as a suitable emblem for Canada.

In 1858, the first official coins to include maple leaves were issued by the Province of Canada on 1, 5, 10 and 20 cent pieces.

In August 1860, at a public meeting held in Toronto, the maple leaf was adopted as the national emblem of Canada for use in the decorations for the Prince of Wales' visit.



Elements of the National Flag of Canada

In 1867, Alexander Muir, a Toronto schoolmaster and poet, composed the song "The Maple Leaf Forever."

In 1914, many Canadian soldiers wore the maple leaf on their military badges, and it was the dominant symbol used by many Canadian regiments serving in World War I.

In 1921, the Royal Arms of Canada were proclaimed by His Majesty King George V with three maple leaves conjoined at the stem holding the commanding position in the shield, creating a distinctively Canadian element.

In 1939, at the beginning of World War II, numerous Canadian troops once again used the maple leaf as a distinctive emblem, displaying it on regimental badges and Canadian army and naval equipment.

In 1996, the maple tree was proclaimed as the National Arboreal Emblem of Canada.

Red and White: Canada's National Colours

Red and white were designated as Canada's official colours in 1921 by His Majesty King George V, in the proclamation of the Royal Arms of Canada. The two colours were significant in that, from the 11th century, red and white were used time and again as the colours of France or England.

Did you know...



- 🍁 Every province and territory in Canada has its own flag. The one symbol that represents us at home and abroad is the red and white National Flag of Canada.
- 🍁 The Canadian Red Ensign flies at the Canadian National Vimy Memorial of the Battle of Vimy Ridge in Vimy, France.
- 🍁 When the Canadian flag flies along with the flags of the 10 provinces and 3 territories, the flags of the provinces and territories follow in the order that they entered Confederation. *
- 🍁 The maple leaf has been used as an emblem in Canada since the eighteenth century. It has often served to distinguish Canadians abroad, as was the case with Canada's first Olympians in 1904.
- 🍁 Red and white were proclaimed Canada's official colours in the proclamation of the Royal Arms of Canada in 1921 by King George V.
- 🍁 Dr. George Stanley, a professor at Royal Military College in Kingston, Ontario, in 1964, suggested a red and white single maple leaf design for the flag because it could be seen clearly from a distance.
- 🍁 The Canadian flag is twice as long as it is wide. The white square and its maple leaf make up half the surface of the flag – equal to the 2 red bars combined.
- 🍁 Vexillologists (flag experts) often cite the National Flag of Canada as one of the world's most beautiful based on its simple design and limited number of colours.
- 🍁 In 1982, Laurie Skreslet, a skier from Calgary, took the Canadian flag to the highest point in the world, Mount Everest. Along with the flag, the expedition was outfitted with 27 tonnes of equipment.
- 🍁 In 1984, the Canadian flag reached new heights when it blasted into space on the flight mission uniform of Marc Garneau, the first Canadian astronaut in space.
- 🍁 In 2005, one of the original maple leaf flags that flew over Parliament on February 15, 1965, was returned to Canada by its owner, Ms. Elisabeth Hoffmann-Lamoureux. The flag was presented to the Prime Minister during the Canada Day celebrations on Parliament Hill.

* For those years when multiple provinces entered Confederation, their flags are arranged by size of population at time of entry. The order of precedence is therefore as follows: Ontario (1867), Quebec (1867), Nova Scotia (1867), New Brunswick (1867), Manitoba (1870), British Columbia (1871), Prince Edward Island (1873), Saskatchewan (1905), Alberta (1905), Newfoundland and Labrador (1949), Northwest Territories (1870), Yukon (1898) and Nunavut (1999).

Flag Do's and Don'ts

Do's

- ✻ The National Flag of Canada should always fly alone on its own mast or flagpole.
- ✻ The National Flag of Canada can be flown at night without being lit.
- ✻ When the National Flag of Canada is raised or lowered, or when it is carried past in a parade or review, people should face the flag, men should remove their hats, and all should remain silent.
- ✻ Half-mast the National Flag of Canada on occasions when a public demonstration of sorrow is called for.
- ✻ Replace a faded or torn flag with a new one. The correct form of disposing of an old flag is by burning it in private.

Don'ts

- ✻ The dimensions/proportions of the National Flag of Canada have an exact ratio of 2 to 1 (twice as long as it is wide), and must not be modified.
- ✻ The National Flag of Canada should not be written on or marked in any way, nor be covered by other objects.
- ✻ Nothing should be pinned or sewn on the National Flag of Canada.
- ✻ The National Flag of Canada should never be dipped or lowered to the ground as means of paying a salute or compliment to any person or thing.